

Hamilton, ON to Yellowstone National Park Road Trip Itinerary

Trip Duration: June 27 - July 11, 2026 (15 Days, 14 Nights)
Travelers: 2 Adults (Couple)
Vehicle: Mitsubishi Outlander PHEV

Trip Overview

Route Summary

- **Outbound Route:** Hamilton → Michigan → Wisconsin → South Dakota → Wyoming → Yellowstone
- **Return Route:** Yellowstone → South Dakota → Iowa → Illinois → **Chicago (overnight)** → Michigan → Ontario
- **Total Distance:** ~5,700 km round trip
- **National Parks Pass:** America the Beautiful Annual Pass - \$80 USD (~\$110 CAD) - **Valid for 1 vehicle and all passengers**

Key Highlights

- Badlands & Wind Cave National Parks
 - Mount Rushmore & Crazy Horse Memorial
 - Devils Tower National Monument
 - Grand Teton National Park
 - Yellowstone National Park (3 nights)
 - **Chicago downtown overnight (Day 13)**
 - Multiple scenic drives with minimal trekking
 - Cedar Rapids overnight option (flexible)
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Day-by-Day Itinerary

Day 1: Saturday, June 27, 2026

Route: Hamilton, ON → Mackinaw City, MI
Distance: 650 km | **Driving Time:** 6.5 hours

Attractions & Stops

- **Morning:** Depart Hamilton 9:00 AM ET
- **Lunch Stop:** Windsor/Sarnia border crossing (~2 hours)
 - Cross into Detroit via Ambassador Bridge or Blue Water Bridge
- **Afternoon:** Drive through Michigan
 - Optional: Quick stop at Port Huron beach
- **Evening:** Arrive Mackinaw City (~4:30 PM ET)
 - Walk along the waterfront

- View Mackinac Bridge at sunset
- Visit Colonial Michilimackinac State Park (if time permits)

Accommodation

Super 8 by Wyndham Mackinaw City

- Address: 519 S Nicolet St, Mackinaw City, MI 49701
- Features: Level 2 EV charging, free breakfast, Wi-Fi
- Rate: \$95 USD/night (~\$131 CAD)

Dining

- **Lunch:** Border area - Tim Hortons or quick stop (\$25 CAD)
- **Dinner:** Mackinaw Grille, Mackinaw City (casual American)
 - Entrees: \$15-25 USD per person
 - Estimated: \$60 USD (~\$83 CAD) for two

Daily Cost Breakdown

Item	Cost (CAD)
Accommodation	\$131
Meals	\$108
Gas (~60L @ \$1.60/L)	\$96
Border toll	\$5
Daily Total	\$340

Day 2: Sunday, June 28, 2026

Route: Mackinaw City, MI → Wisconsin Dells, WI

Distance: 630 km | **Driving Time:** 6.5 hours

Attractions & Stops

- **Morning:** Depart 8:30 AM, cross Mackinac Bridge (\$4 USD toll)
- **En Route:** Drive through Upper Peninsula Michigan & Wisconsin
 - Stop at Menominee River scenic overlook
- **Afternoon:** Arrive Wisconsin Dells (~3:00 PM CT)
 - Visit Mirror Lake State Park (free, natural beauty)
 - Walk through downtown Dells
 - Optional: Witches Gulch or Lost Canyon tours (\$15-20 USD pp)

Accommodation

Days Inn by Wyndham Wisconsin Dells

- Address: 944 Highway 13, Wisconsin Dells, WI 53965
- Features: Free breakfast, Wi-Fi, outdoor pool
- Rate: \$88 USD/night (~\$121 CAD)

Dining

- **Breakfast:** Included at hotel
- **Lunch:** Roadside stop in Wisconsin (\$30 CAD)
- **Dinner:** Moosejaw Pizza & Dells Brewing Co. (casual)
 - Estimated: \$55 USD (~\$76 CAD) for two

Daily Cost Breakdown

Item	Cost (CAD)
Accommodation	\$121
Meals	\$106
Gas (~57L @ \$1.60/L)	\$91
Mackinac Bridge toll	\$6
Optional tour (if taken)	\$55
Daily Total	\$324 (or \$379 with tour)

Day 3: Monday, June 29, 2026

Route: Wisconsin Dells, WI → Rapid City, SD
Distance: 770 km | **Driving Time:** 7.5 hours

Attractions & Stops

- **Morning:** Depart 8:00 AM CT
- **En Route:** Drive through Minnesota & South Dakota
 - Stop at Minnesota Welcome Center
 - Lunch in Mitchell, SD - see the Corn Palace (free, quirky attraction)
- **Evening:** Arrive Rapid City (~4:30 PM MT)
 - Walk around downtown Rapid City
 - Visit City of Presidents walking tour (free bronze statues)

Accommodation

Fairfield Inn & Suites Rapid City

- Address: 1314 N Elk Vale Rd, Rapid City, SD 57703
- Features: Level 2 EV charging, free breakfast, indoor pool
- Rate: \$105 USD/night (~\$145 CAD)

Dining

- **Breakfast:** Included at hotel
- **Lunch:** Corn Palace Café, Mitchell, SD (\$28 CAD)
- **Dinner:** Tally's Silver Spoon, Rapid City (classic American diner)
 - Estimated: \$50 USD (~\$69 CAD) for two

Daily Cost Breakdown

Item	Cost (CAD)
Accommodation	\$145
Meals	\$97
Gas (~70L @ \$1.60/L)	\$112
Daily Total	\$354

Day 4: Tuesday, June 30, 2026

Route: Rapid City, SD (Day Trip Loop)
Distance: 240 km loop | **Driving Time:** 5 hours total (with stops)

Attractions & Stops - FULL DAY OF SIGHTSEEING

- **Morning:**
 - Depart 8:00 AM
 - **Mount Rushmore National Memorial** (1.5-2 hours)
 - Entry: Included in America the Beautiful Pass (otherwise \$10 parking)
 - View from Grand View Terrace (no hiking required)
 - Photo ops from multiple viewing platforms
 - **Custer State Park** (2-3 hours)
 - Wildlife Loop Road - scenic drive to see bison, pronghorn, burros
 - Needles Highway scenic drive (stunning rock formations)
 - Sylvan Lake scenic area (short walk, optional)
 - Entry: \$20 USD per vehicle (~\$28 CAD)
- **Afternoon:**
 - **Crazy Horse Memorial** (1 hour)
 - Entry: \$15 USD per person (~\$41 CAD for two)
 - View from visitor center terrace (no hiking)
 - Return to Rapid City via Iron Mountain Road (scenic tunnels framing Mount Rushmore)

Accommodation

Fairfield Inn & Suites Rapid City (same as previous night)

- Rate: \$105 USD/night (~\$145 CAD)

Dining

- **Breakfast:** Included at hotel
- **Lunch:** State Game Lodge, Custer State Park (buffalo burger!)
 - Estimated: \$45 USD (~\$62 CAD) for two
- **Dinner:** Murphy's Pub & Grill, Rapid City (casual pub)
 - Estimated: \$48 USD (~\$66 CAD) for two

Daily Cost Breakdown

Item	Cost (CAD)
Accommodation	\$145
Meals	\$128
Gas (~22L @ \$1.60/L)	\$35
Custer State Park entry	\$28
Crazy Horse entry	\$41
Daily Total	\$377

Day 5: Wednesday, July 1, 2026 (Canada Day!)

Route: Rapid City, SD → Cody, WY
Distance: 560 km | **Driving Time:** 6 hours

Attractions & Stops

- **Morning:**
 - Depart 8:00 AM
 - **Badlands National Park** (2-3 hours) - MUST SEE!
 - Entry: Included in America the Beautiful Pass
 - Drive Badlands Loop Road (Hwy 240) - 31 miles of scenic overlooks
 - Stop at multiple viewpoints: Pinnacles Overlook, Yellow Mounds, Panorama Point, Big Badlands Overlook
 - Optional short walks at Door Trail (0.75 km boardwalk - wheelchair accessible)
 - Fossil Exhibit Trail (0.4 km boardwalk)
- **Afternoon:**
 - Continue through Wyoming
 - Stop at **Devils Tower National Monument** (1.5 hours)
 - Entry: Included in America the Beautiful Pass
 - View from Red Beds Trail or parking area viewpoints (no climbing required)
 - Visitor Center for geology exhibits
- **Evening:** Arrive Cody, WY

Accommodation

Hampton Inn Cody

- Address: 1807 Sheridan Ave, Cody, WY 82414
- Features: Level 2 EV charging, free breakfast, indoor pool
- Rate: \$115 USD/night (~\$159 CAD)

Dining

- **Breakfast:** Included at hotel
- **Lunch:** Cedar Pass Lodge, Badlands (pack sandwiches or grab from lodge)
 - Estimated: \$35 CAD
- **Dinner:** Wyoming's Rib & Chop House, Cody (Western steakhouse)
 - Estimated: \$60 USD (~\$83 CAD) for two

Daily Cost Breakdown

Item	Cost (CAD)
Accommodation	\$159
Meals	\$118
Gas (~51L @ \$1.60/L)	\$82
Daily Total	\$359

Day 6: Thursday, July 2, 2026

Route: Cody, WY → West Yellowstone, MT
Distance: 200 km | **Driving Time:** 2.5 hours

Attractions & Stops

- **Morning:**
 - Visit **Buffalo Bill Center of the West** (2-3 hours)
 - Entry: \$21 USD per person (~\$58 CAD for two)
 - 5 museums in one - excellent Western history
- **Afternoon:**
 - Scenic drive to West Yellowstone
 - Drive through **Shoshone National Forest**
 - Stop at **Yellowstone Lake** overlooks
- **Evening:**
 - Arrive West Yellowstone
 - Walk around town, visit shops

Accommodation

Stage Coach Inn - West Yellowstone

- Address: 209 Madison Ave, West Yellowstone, MT 59758
- Features: Level 2 EV charging (ChargePoint), free breakfast, hot tub

- Rate: \$135 USD/night (~\$186 CAD)

Dining

- **Breakfast:** Included at hotel
- **Lunch:** Quick bite in Cody before departure (\$30 CAD)
- **Dinner:** Wild West Pizzeria & Saloon, West Yellowstone
 - Estimated: \$55 USD (~\$76 CAD) for two

Daily Cost Breakdown

Item	Cost (CAD)
Accommodation	\$186
Meals	\$106
Gas (~18L @ \$1.60/L)	\$29
Buffalo Bill Center entry	\$58
Daily Total	\$379

Day 7: Friday, July 3, 2026

YELLOWSTONE NATIONAL PARK - Day 1 (Lower Loop)

Distance: 150 km in park | **Driving Time:** Full day with stops

Attractions & Stops

- **Morning:**
 - Enter Yellowstone West Entrance (7:00 AM - beat crowds!)
 - **Lower Geyser Basin** - Fountain Paint Pot (easy boardwalk)
 - **Midway Geyser Basin** - Grand Prismatic Spring (1.5 hours)
 - Walk boardwalk loop (easy, flat, 0.8 km)
 - Optional: Grand Prismatic Overlook Trail (1.3 km uphill - skip if preferred)
 - **Old Faithful** area (2-3 hours)
 - Watch Old Faithful erupt (every ~90 minutes)
 - Upper Geyser Basin boardwalk (multiple geysers - easy walking)
 - Visit historic Old Faithful Inn interior
 - Morning Glory Pool (easy boardwalk extension)
- **Afternoon:**
 - **West Thumb Geyser Basin** on Yellowstone Lake (1 hour)
 - Lakeside boardwalk with thermal features
 - Drive along **Yellowstone Lake** shore (largest high-elevation lake in North America)
 - Stop at Lake Butte Overlook for panoramic views
- **Evening:** Return to West Yellowstone

Accommodation

Stage Coach Inn - West Yellowstone (same hotel)

- Rate: \$135 USD/night (~\$186 CAD)

Dining

- **Breakfast:** Included at hotel
- **Lunch:** Pack sandwiches/snacks (buy groceries evening before)
 - Cost: \$25 CAD
- **Dinner:** Running Bear Pancake House, West Yellowstone
 - Estimated: \$50 USD (~\$69 CAD) for two

Daily Cost Breakdown

Item	Cost (CAD)
Accommodation	\$186
Meals	\$94
Gas (~14L @ \$1.60/L)	\$22
Groceries for next day	\$30
Daily Total	\$332

Day 8: Saturday, July 4, 2026 (Independence Day)**YELLOWSTONE NATIONAL PARK - Day 2 (Upper Loop)**

Distance: 180 km in park | **Driving Time:** Full day with stops

NOTE: Park will be VERY CROWDED today. Start EARLY (6:00 AM).

Attractions & Stops

- **Morning:**
 - Depart hotel 6:00 AM
 - **Norris Geyser Basin** (1.5 hours)
 - Most dynamic thermal area in park - two boardwalk loops (easy walking)
 - Porcelain Basin and Back Basin boardwalks
 - **Mammoth Hot Springs** (2 hours)
 - Upper and Lower Terraces boardwalks (stunning white travertine formations)
 - Mammoth Hot Springs Hotel area
 - Elk commonly graze on the lawns (photo op!)
- **Afternoon:**
 - **Tower-Roosevelt** area (scenic drive through Roosevelt Country)
 - **Grand Canyon of the Yellowstone** (2-3 hours) - MUST SEE!
 - Artist Point (iconic view of Lower Falls - paved, easy access)
 - Lookout Point (shorter walk to canyon rim)
 - Brink of Lower Falls viewpoint (optional - steep but worth it)

- Skip Uncle Tom's Trail (328 steps down and back up - very strenuous)
- **Evening:**
 - **Hayden Valley** - prime wildlife viewing area (bison herds, elk, possibly grizzly bears)
 - Stop at pullouts for photography
 - Return to West Yellowstone

Accommodation

Stage Coach Inn - West Yellowstone (same hotel)

- Rate: \$145 USD/night (~\$200 CAD) - **Holiday premium pricing**

Dining

- **Breakfast:** Included at hotel (eat early, 6:00 AM buffet)
- **Lunch:** Packed lunch from groceries (\$0 - already purchased)
- **Dinner:** Serenity Bistro, West Yellowstone (casual American)
 - Estimated: \$58 USD (~\$80 CAD) for two

Daily Cost Breakdown

Item	Cost (CAD)
Accommodation	\$200
Meals	\$80
Gas (~16L @ \$1.60/L)	\$26
Daily Total	\$306

Day 9: Sunday, July 5, 2026

YELLOWSTONE + GRAND TETON - Day 3

Route: West Yellowstone → Jackson, WY

Distance: 180 km | **Driving Time:** 4 hours with stops

Attractions & Stops

- **Morning:**
 - Early start (7:00 AM)
 - **Lamar Valley** (wildlife viewing - "Serengeti of North America")
 - Drive-through viewing from car (no hiking needed)
 - Best for wolves, bison, bears, elk
 - OR revisit favorite Yellowstone spots from previous days
- **Afternoon:**
 - Exit Yellowstone South Entrance
 - **Grand Teton National Park** (3-4 hours)
 - Entry: Included in America the Beautiful Pass

- **Jenny Lake scenic area** - drive to viewpoint (short walk to lakefront optional)
- **Snake River Overlook** - iconic Ansel Adams viewpoint (roadside pullout)
- **Schwabacher Landing** - reflection view of Tetons (short walk from parking)
- **Mormon Row Historic District** - famous T.A. Moulton Barn photos (drive-up access)
- **Oxbow Bend** - stunning reflection viewpoint (roadside)
- **Evening:** Arrive Jackson

Accommodation

Elk Country Inn - Jackson Hole

- Address: 480 W Pearl Ave, Jackson, WY 83001
- Features: Free breakfast, Wi-Fi
- Rate: \$125 USD/night (~\$172 CAD)

Dining

- **Breakfast:** Included at hotel
- **Lunch:** Packed snacks from groceries
- **Dinner:** Bubba's Bar-B-Que, Jackson (casual BBQ)
 - Estimated: \$55 USD (~\$76 CAD) for two

Daily Cost Breakdown

Item	Cost (CAD)
Accommodation	\$172
Meals	\$76
Gas (~16L @ \$1.60/L)	\$26
Daily Total	\$274

Day 10: Monday, July 6, 2026

Route: Jackson, WY → Custer, SD
Distance: 750 km | **Driving Time:** 7.5 hours

Attractions & Stops

- **Morning:**
 - Depart Jackson 8:00 AM
 - Quick walk around Jackson Town Square (elk antler arches)
- **En Route:**
 - Long driving day back through Wyoming and into South Dakota
 - Lunch stop in Lusk or Newcastle, WY
- **Afternoon:**
 - **Wind Cave National Park** (if time permits - 1-2 hours)

- Entry: Included in America the Beautiful Pass
- Cave tours available (\$15 USD pp if interested)
- Or just drive through for wildlife viewing
- **Evening:** Arrive Custer, SD

Accommodation

Comfort Inn & Suites Custer

- Address: 340 W Mt Rushmore Rd, Custer, SD 57730
- Features: Free breakfast, Wi-Fi, indoor pool
- Rate: \$98 USD/night (~\$135 CAD)

Dining

- **Breakfast:** Included at hotel
- **Lunch:** Roadside diner in Wyoming (\$35 CAD)
- **Dinner:** Skogen Kitchen, Custer (American comfort food)
 - Estimated: \$50 USD (~\$69 CAD) for two

Daily Cost Breakdown

Item	Cost (CAD)
Accommodation	\$135
Meals	\$104
Gas (~68L @ \$1.60/L)	\$109
Daily Total	\$348

Day 11: Tuesday, July 7, 2026

Route: Custer, SD → Sioux Falls, SD
Distance: 450 km | **Driving Time:** 4.5 hours

Attractions & Stops

- **Morning:**
 - Revisit any Rapid City/Mount Rushmore area if desired
 - OR depart directly around 9:00 AM
- **En Route:**
 - Drive through South Dakota plains
 - Stop at **Mitchell Corn Palace** (if missed earlier)
- **Afternoon:**
 - Arrive Sioux Falls (~2:00 PM)
 - Visit **Falls Park** (free, beautiful waterfalls in city!)
 - Walk around downtown

- SculptureWalk (free outdoor art)
- **Evening:** Relax at hotel

Accommodation

La Quinta Inn & Suites Sioux Falls

- Address: 4520 E Arrowhead Pkwy, Sioux Falls, SD 57110
- Features: Level 2 EV charging, free breakfast
- Rate: \$92 USD/night (~\$127 CAD)

Dining

- **Breakfast:** Included at hotel
- **Lunch:** En route stop (\$30 CAD)
- **Dinner:** JL Beers, Sioux Falls (burgers & craft beer)
 - Estimated: \$48 USD (~\$66 CAD) for two

Daily Cost Breakdown

Item	Cost (CAD)
Accommodation	\$127
Meals	\$96
Gas (~41L @ \$1.60/L)	\$66
Daily Total	\$289

Day 12: Wednesday, July 8, 2026

Route: Sioux Falls, SD → Des Moines, IA
Distance: 400 km | **Driving Time:** 4 hours

Attractions & Stops

- **Morning:**
 - Depart Sioux Falls 9:00 AM
- **En Route:**
 - Drive through Iowa farmland
- **Afternoon:**
 - Arrive Des Moines (~1:00 PM)
 - Visit **Iowa State Capitol** (free tours)
 - Walk around **Pappajohn Sculpture Park** (free)
 - East Village shopping district
- **Evening:** Relax at hotel

Accommodation

Hampton Inn & Suites Des Moines Downtown

- Address: 120 SW Water St, Des Moines, IA 50309
- Features: Level 2 EV charging, free breakfast
- Rate: \$105 USD/night (~\$145 CAD)

Dining

- **Breakfast:** Included at hotel
- **Lunch:** Roadside stop (\$28 CAD)
- **Dinner:** Zombie Burger + Drink Lab, Des Moines (fun burgers)
 - Estimated: \$45 USD (~\$62 CAD) for two

Daily Cost Breakdown

Item	Cost (CAD)
Accommodation	\$145
Meals	\$90
Gas (~36L @ \$1.60/L)	\$58
Daily Total	\$293

Day 13: Thursday, July 9, 2026

Route: Des Moines, IA → Chicago, IL
Distance: 530 km | **Driving Time:** 5.5 hours

Attractions & Stops

- **Morning:**
 - Depart Des Moines 8:00 AM
- **En Route:**
 - Drive through Iowa and Illinois
 - Lunch stop in Moline or Rock Island, IL
- **Afternoon:**
 - Arrive Chicago (~2:00 PM CT)
 - **Millennium Park** - Cloud Gate "The Bean" (free, iconic photo op!)
 - Walk along **Chicago Riverwalk**
 - **Navy Pier** (free to walk, optional activities)
- **Evening:**
 - Dinner in Chicago
 - Optional: **360 Chicago observation deck** or **Skydeck Chicago** (Willis Tower)
 - Entry: ~\$30 USD per person (~\$82 CAD for two) if interested

Accommodation

Hampton Inn Chicago Downtown/N Loop/Michigan Ave

- Address: 68 E Wacker Pl, Chicago, IL 60601
- Features: Level 2 EV charging nearby, free breakfast, central location
- Rate: \$145 USD/night (~\$200 CAD)

Dining

- **Breakfast:** Included at hotel
- **Lunch:** Roadside stop in Illinois (\$30 CAD)
- **Dinner:** Giordano's or Lou Malnati's (famous Chicago deep dish pizza!)
 - Estimated: \$65 USD (~\$90 CAD) for two

Daily Cost Breakdown

Item	Cost (CAD)
Accommodation	\$200
Meals	\$120
Gas (~48L @ \$1.60/L)	\$77
Optional observation deck	\$82
Parking (if needed)	\$40
Daily Total	\$437 (or \$519 with observation deck)

Day 14: Friday, July 10, 2026

Route: Chicago, IL → Kalamazoo, MI
Distance: 240 km | **Driving Time:** 3 hours

Attractions & Stops

- **Morning:**
 - Leisurely breakfast at hotel
 - Final walk around Chicago if time permits
 - **Optional:** Art Institute of Chicago or Chicago Architecture River Cruise
 - Depart Chicago 10:00 AM
- **En Route:**
 - Drive along Lake Michigan shore through Indiana
 - **Indiana Dunes National Park** (optional 1-2 hour stop)
 - Entry: Included in America the Beautiful Pass
 - Beach views, short walks to overlooks
- **Afternoon:**
 - Arrive Kalamazoo (~2:00 PM ET)
 - Relax at hotel
 - Walk around downtown Kalamazoo

- **Kalamazoo Valley Museum** (free admission)
- **Evening:**
 - Rest and prepare for final day

Accommodation

Fairfield Inn & Suites Kalamazoo

- Address: 3800 Easy St, Portage, MI 49002
- Features: Level 2 EV charging, free breakfast
- Rate: \$95 USD/night (~\$131 CAD)

Dining

- **Breakfast:** Included at hotel
- **Lunch:** En route in Indiana (\$32 CAD)
- **Dinner:** Bell's Brewery, Kalamazoo (local craft brewery & pub)
 - Estimated: \$52 USD (~\$72 CAD) for two

Daily Cost Breakdown

Item	Cost (CAD)
Accommodation	\$131
Meals	\$104
Gas (~22L @ \$1.60/L)	\$35
Daily Total	\$270

Day 15: Saturday, July 11, 2026

Route: Kalamazoo, MI → Hamilton, ON
Distance: 450 km | **Driving Time:** 5 hours

Attractions & Stops

- **Morning:**
 - Final hotel breakfast
 - Depart Kalamazoo 9:00 AM
- **En Route:**
 - Drive through Michigan toward Canadian border
 - Cross at Detroit/Windsor or Port Huron/Sarnia
- **Afternoon:**
 - Arrive HOME in Hamilton! (~2:00-3:00 PM ET)

Dining

- **Breakfast:** Included at hotel

- **Lunch:** Border area or back home! (\$25 CAD)

Daily Cost Breakdown

Item	Cost (CAD)
Meals	\$25
Gas (~41L @ \$1.60/L)	\$66
Border crossing	\$5
Daily Total	\$96

Complete Cost Breakdown Summary

Accommodation (14 nights)

Location	Nights	Total CAD
Mackinaw City, MI	1	\$131
Wisconsin Dells, WI	1	\$121
Rapid City, SD	2	\$290
Cody, WY	1	\$159
West Yellowstone, MT	3	\$572
Jackson, WY	1	\$172
Custer, SD	1	\$135
Sioux Falls, SD	1	\$127
Des Moines, IA	1	\$145
Chicago, IL	1	\$200
Kalamazoo, MI	1	\$131
TOTAL ACCOMMODATION	14	\$2,183

Meals (15 days)

- Average per day: \$98 CAD
- **TOTAL MEALS: \$1,470 CAD**

Fuel (5,700 km total)

- Estimated consumption: 530 liters total
- Rate: \$1.60/L CAD average
- **TOTAL FUEL: \$848 CAD**

Park Entries & Attractions

Attraction	Cost CAD
America the Beautiful Annual Pass	\$110
Custer State Park	\$28
Crazy Horse Memorial	\$41
Buffalo Bill Center	\$58
Chicago parking (1 day)	\$40
Bridge/border tolls	\$20
Optional Wisconsin Dells tour	\$55
Optional Chicago observation deck	\$82
TOTAL ENTRIES	\$297 (or \$434 with all optional activities)

Miscellaneous

- Groceries/snacks: \$55 CAD
- Emergency fund: \$150 CAD
- **TOTAL MISC: \$205 CAD**

GRAND TOTAL COST

Category	Cost (CAD)
Accommodation	\$2,183
Meals	\$1,470
Fuel	\$848
Attractions/Entries	\$297
Miscellaneous	\$205
TOTAL	\$5,003 CAD
Per Person	\$2,502 CAD

Cost per day: ~\$334 CAD

With all optional activities: ~\$5,140 CAD total

Important Notes & Tips

National Parks Pass

- **America the Beautiful Annual Pass: \$80 USD (~\$110 CAD)**
- **Covers 1 vehicle and all passengers** - perfect for couples!
- Valid at: Yellowstone, Grand Teton, Badlands, Wind Cave, Devils Tower, Mount Rushmore, Indiana Dunes
- Purchase at first park (Badlands on Day 5) or buy online beforehand at store.usgs.gov/recreationpass
- Physical pass ships within 3 weeks - allow time or buy at park
- Keep pass in glove box for easy access at park entrances

EV Charging Strategy for Mitsubishi Outlander PHEV

- **PHEV charging planned at:** Mackinaw City, Rapid City, Cody, West Yellowstone (3 nights), Sioux Falls, Des Moines, Chicago, Kalamazoo
- All Level 2 overnight charging at hotels (220V, 3-5 hour full charge)
- **Cost:** Most hotel chargers are complimentary or \$5-10 per session
- Can run hybrid mode continuously if needed - don't worry about charging gaps
- **ChargePoint and PlugShare apps** - find public charging stations en route
- Electric range: ~35-40 km per charge; use for city driving to save gas
- **Tip:** Request room near charging station when checking in

Vehicle Preparation & Road Trip Essentials

- **Pre-departure vehicle inspection:**
 - Oil change if due within trip dates
 - Check tire pressure and tread depth (including spare)
 - Top off all fluids (coolant, brake fluid, windshield washer)
 - Test lights, wipers, horn
 - Check battery health
 - Verify PHEV charging cable is in vehicle
- **Emergency car kit:**
 - Jumper cables
 - Tire inflator/sealant
 - Flashlight with extra batteries
 - Basic tool kit
 - Duct tape
 - Ice scraper (even in summer - high elevations!)
 - Tow rope
- **CAA/AAA membership:** Verify coverage extends to USA
- **Vehicle documents:** Registration, insurance card (verify USA coverage), driver's licenses

July 4th in Yellowstone - CRITICAL PLANNING

- **Expect HUGE crowds** - busiest day of the year (100,000+ visitors)
- **Start at 6:00 AM or EARLIER** - parking lots fill by 8:00 AM
- Pack breakfast and lunch to avoid 1-2 hour restaurant waits
- Be patient with parking (may need to wait 30+ min at popular spots)
- Wildlife jams can add 1-2 hours to drive times
- Book accommodation 6+ months in advance (already reflected in pricing)
- Gas stations in West Yellowstone will have long lines - fill up night before
- Consider alternate plans if weather is bad (thunderstorms common)

- **Tip:** Old Faithful area is most crowded - prioritize morning visit

Money-Saving Tips

1. **Hotel breakfasts:** All hotels include free breakfast - saves \$20-30/day CAD
2. **Pack lunches:** Buy groceries for in-park days (bread, deli meat, cheese, fruit, snacks)
3. **Gas apps:** Use GasBuddy or Waze for cheapest gas stations (can save \$10-20/tank)
4. **Annual Pass:** Saves \$70+ USD vs buying individual park entries
5. **Off-peak dining:** Eat lunch as main meal (dinner prices are 20-30% higher)
6. **Avoid tourist traps:** Skip overpriced gift shops in gateway towns
7. **Free water:** Refill bottles at park visitor centers instead of buying
8. **Group discounts:** Ask about CAA/AAA discounts at hotels and attractions
9. **Credit card rewards:** Use travel rewards card for USD purchases (check foreign transaction fees)

Border Crossing Tips - USA Entry & Return to Canada

Entering USA (Days 1 & 15):

- Bring passports (REQUIRED - no exceptions)
- NEXUS cards if you have them (use NEXUS lanes for faster processing)
- Border wait times: Check cbp.gov/bwt before crossing
- **Best crossing points:** Ambassador Bridge (Detroit/Windsor) or Blue Water Bridge (Port Huron/Sarnia)
- **Peak wait times:** Weekdays 7-9 AM, 4-6 PM; Weekends 10 AM-4 PM
- Have hotel address ready for first night (border agent may ask)
- Declare all food items (no fresh fruits/vegetables allowed into USA)

Returning to Canada (Day 15):

- Duty-free exemption after 48+ hours: \$800 CAD per person
- Declare ALL purchases (receipts ready)
- Alcohol limit: 1.5L wine OR 1.14L spirits OR 8.5L beer per person
- Tobacco limits apply
- Border services: cbsa-asfc.gc.ca
- **ArriveCAN may be required** - check current requirements before trip

Weather Considerations (Late June/Early July)

- **Yellowstone elevations:** 2,000-3,000m (6,500-9,800 ft)
- **Temperature ranges:**
 - Yellowstone: 5-25°C days, -2 to 5°C nights
 - South Dakota: 20-30°C days, 10-15°C nights
 - Chicago: 22-28°C, humid
- **Afternoon thunderstorms** common in mountains (2-4 PM)
- **Snow possible** at high elevations even in July
- **Layering is key:** Start day with jacket, strip to t-shirt by noon
- **UV intensity:** High elevation = stronger sun (SPF 50+ recommended)
- **Wildfire season:** Check air quality forecasts (AirNow.gov)

What to Pack - Complete Packing List

Documents & Money:

- ☐ Passports (check expiry - must be valid 6+ months)
- ☐ Driver's licenses
- ☐ Vehicle registration & insurance
- ☐ Credit cards (notify banks of travel dates)
- ☐ USD cash (\$200-300 for tolls, tips, emergencies)
- ☐ Health insurance cards
- ☐ Hotel confirmation printouts (backup if phone dies)
- ☐ National Parks Pass (if pre-purchased)

Clothing:

- ☐ Comfortable walking shoes (broken in!)
- ☐ Sandals for hotel/evening
- ☐ 7-8 outfits (mix-and-match layers)
- ☐ Light rain jacket (waterproof)
- ☐ Fleece or warm sweater
- ☐ Hat (sun protection)
- ☐ Sunglasses (UV protection)
- ☐ Underwear & socks (10 days worth)
- ☐ Sleepwear
- ☐ Light jacket for evenings
- ☐ Swimsuit (hotel pools)

Health & Hygiene:

- ☐ Prescription medications (2-week supply + extra)
- ☐ First aid kit (bandaids, pain relievers, antihistamines)
- ☐ Sunscreen SPF 50+
- ☐ Lip balm with SPF
- ☐ Insect repellent (mosquitoes/ticks)
- ☐ Hand sanitizer
- ☐ Toiletries (travel-size TSA compliant even though driving)
- ☐ Motion sickness medication (winding mountain roads)
- ☐ Allergy medication
- ☐ Tweezers (for splinters/ticks)
- ☐ Moleskin (for blisters)

Electronics:

- ☐ Phone & charger
- ☐ Car charger (USB ports)
- ☐ Camera & memory cards
- ☐ Portable power bank (10,000+ mAh)
- ☐ Headphones
- ☐ EV charging cable (for PHEV)
- ☐ Laptop/tablet (optional)
- ☐ Plug adapter (USA uses same as Canada)

Vehicle & Navigation:

- ☐ Outlander PHEV owner's manual
- ☐ Printed copy of itinerary
- ☐ Offline maps downloaded (Google Maps)
- ☐ Physical road atlas (backup)
- ☐ Binoculars (wildlife viewing)
- ☐ Cooler for drinks/snacks
- ☐ Reusable water bottles (2+)
- ☐ Trash bags for car
- ☐ Wet wipes/tissues

Food & Snacks:

- ☐ Non-perishable snacks (granola bars, nuts, dried fruit)
- ☐ Sandwich bags
- ☐ Napkins/paper towels
- ☐ Utensils (reusable fork, spoon, knife)
- ☐ Can opener (if bringing canned goods)

Optional But Recommended:

- ☐ National park guidebook
- ☐ Wildlife identification guide
- ☐ Hiking poles (if doing any optional walks)
- ☐ Bear spray (if nervous, though unlikely to need)
- ☐ Gaiters (if venturing off boardwalks)
- ☐ Notebook/journal for memories
- ☐ Playing cards (for hotel downtime)
- ☐ Portable speaker (low volume for hotel)

Booking Recommendations

- **Book hotels NOW** - July is absolute peak season (especially July 4th weekend)
- Yellowstone area fills up 9-12 months in advance
- **Travel insurance:** Consider for trip cancellation/medical emergencies (\$80-120 CAD)
 - Check credit card travel insurance coverage first
- **Refundable rates:** Pay 10-15% more for flexibility if dates uncertain
- **Download offline maps:**
 - Google Maps: Save offline area for each state
 - Yellowstone NPS app: Full park map offline
- **Reserve rental equipment:** If considering bike rentals, book ahead

Cell Phone Coverage - Know the Dead Zones**Good coverage:**

- All major cities and highways
- Most of South Dakota (I-90 corridor)
- Chicago area

- Michigan

Spotty/No coverage:

- **Yellowstone:** 60% of park has no service (Verizon best)
- **Grand Teton:** Limited to main roads
- **Rural Wyoming:** Large gaps between towns
- **Upper Michigan:** Patches along US-2
- **Badlands:** Visitor centers only

Solutions:

- Download offline maps for entire route
- Screenshot hotel addresses/phone numbers
- Print physical itinerary
- Let family know you may be unreachable for days
- Purchase prepaid satellite communicator (\$50 rental for trip) if concerned

Food Storage & Wildlife Safety - CRITICAL

Wildlife Distance Rules:

- **25 meters (75 feet):** Bison, elk, deer, moose, bighorn sheep
- **100 meters (300 feet):** Bears, wolves, coyotes
- **Use zoom lens** for photos - NOT zoom feet!

Wildlife Behavior:

- **Bison:** Unpredictable, can run 50 km/h, cause most injuries in Yellowstone
- **Bears:** Active dawn/dusk, attracted to food smells
- **Elk:** Aggressive during calving (May-June) and rut (Sept-Oct)
- **Moose:** Most dangerous - give widest berth

Food Storage in Parks:

- Never leave food in open vehicle
- Store in hard-sided containers or trunk
- No food in tent (if camping)
- Use bear-proof trash cans
- Don't eat in car then leave windows down

If Wildlife Approaches:

- Stay calm, don't run
- Back away slowly
- Make yourself big if bear approaches
- Get in vehicle if available
- Use bear spray only as last resort (within 7-10m)

Wildlife Jams:

- Pull fully off road (not half on shoulder)

- Stay in vehicle
- Don't contribute to crowding animals
- Be patient - jams can last 30-60 minutes

Driving Safety - Mountain & Rural Roads

- **Speed limits:** Strictly enforced in national parks (45 mph / 70 km/h max)
- **Curves:** Many mountain roads have sharp hairpin turns (10-20 mph / 15-30 km/h)
- **Elevation:** Engine may feel sluggish above 2,500m - downshift as needed
- **Brakes:** Use low gear on descents to avoid brake fade
- **Wildlife crossings:** Dawn/dusk most dangerous - scan roadsides constantly
- **Fuel planning:** In Wyoming, gas stations can be 100+ km apart - fill at half tank
- **Fatigue:** Stop every 2 hours, rotate drivers
- **Weather changes:** Can go from sun to snow in 30 minutes at elevation

Health & Safety Considerations

Altitude Sickness Prevention:

- Yellowstone is 2,300m (7,500 ft) - some may feel effects
- Symptoms: Headache, nausea, fatigue, dizziness
- **Prevention:** Hydrate (3-4L water/day), avoid alcohol first 24h, rest frequently
- **Treatment:** Descend to lower elevation, ibuprofen, hydrate

Sun Protection:

- UV rays 25-30% stronger at high elevation
- Reapply sunscreen every 2 hours
- Wear hat and sunglasses always
- Cloudy days still cause sunburn

Hydration:

- Bring 2L water per person per day
- Refill at visitor centers (free, filtered)
- Coffee/soda don't count - need plain water
- Signs of dehydration: Dark urine, headache, dizziness

Medical Facilities:

- **Yellowstone:** Clinics at Mammoth, Old Faithful, Lake (May-Sept only)
- **Emergency:** Dial 911 from any park phone
- **Nearest hospitals:** Jackson (WY), Cody (WY), Bozeman (MT)
- **Travel insurance:** Verify USA coverage for medical emergencies

Photography Tips - Capture the Memories

Best Photo Locations:

- Grand Prismatic Spring (mid-day for best colors)
- Old Faithful (position upwind for no steam in shot)

- Grand Canyon of Yellowstone - Artist Point (morning light)
- Mormon Row barn (sunrise/sunset)
- Mount Rushmore (morning light, avoid noon shadows)
- Cloud Gate/The Bean in Chicago (early morning, fewer crowds)

Camera Settings:

- Wildlife: Fast shutter (1/500+), telephoto lens
- Landscapes: Small aperture (f/11-f/16), wide angle
- Geysers: Burst mode to catch eruptions
- Sunrises/sunsets: Tripod, bracket exposures

Drone Rules:

- **Prohibited in ALL national parks** - \$5,000+ fine if caught
- OK in some state parks (check regulations)
- Chicago requires permits

Emergency Preparedness

Emergency Contacts:

- **USA Emergency:** 911
- **Yellowstone Dispatch:** 307-344-7381
- **Roadside Assistance:** CAA 1-800-222-4357
- **Poison Control:** 1-800-222-1222
- **Canadian Consulate Chicago:** 312-616-1860

What to Do If:

- **Vehicle breakdown:** Pull off road, hazards on, call CAA
- **Medical emergency:** Call 911, describe location (mile marker or GPS coordinates)
- **Lost/separated:** Stay put, call/text when signal returns
- **Wildlife encounter:** See Wildlife Safety section above
- **Severe weather:** Seek shelter in building or car (not under trees)
- **Lost passport:** Contact Canadian Consulate immediately

Chicago-Specific Tips (Day 13)

- **Parking:** Use SpotHero app to pre-book parking (save 30-50%)
- **CTA Transit:** Consider "L" train from airport-area parking to downtown (save \$40)
- **Peak traffic:** Avoid I-90/94 through city 3-6 PM on weekdays
- **Safety:** Downtown is safe during day; stick to main streets after dark
- **Architecture River Cruise:** \$45 pp, 90 min, highly rated (book ahead)
- **Navy Pier:** Free to walk, \$8-15 for attractions (Ferris wheel \$18)
- **Millennium Park:** Free, open 6 AM-11 PM, check for free concerts
- **Deep dish pizza:** Expect 45-60 min wait for pizza to cook - order ahead!

Hidden Costs to Budget For

- **USA sales tax:** 4-9% depending on state (not included in posted prices)
- **Tipping:** 15-20% at restaurants, \$2-5 for hotel housekeeping
- **Resort fees:** Some hotels charge \$10-20/night (verify when booking)
- **Park parking:** Mount Rushmore \$10 (not covered by annual pass)
- **ATM fees:** \$3-5 per withdrawal (use credit card when possible)
- **Toll roads:** ~\$25 USD total for trip (mostly electronic I-PASS/E-ZPass)
- **Souvenirs:** Budget \$50-100 if interested in keepsakes

Top 15 Must-See Sites - No Hiking Required!

All these attractions are accessible via car, short walks, or wheelchair-accessible boardwalks:

1. **Grand Prismatic Spring, Yellowstone** - Easy boardwalk loop, most photographed thermal feature
2. **Old Faithful Geyser, Yellowstone** - View from benches, erupts every 90 minutes
3. **Grand Canyon of Yellowstone - Artist Point** - Paved path to iconic waterfall view
4. **Mount Rushmore** - View from Grand View Terrace, no climbing required
5. **Badlands Overlooks** - 13 scenic pullouts along Loop Road, all roadside
6. **Mammoth Hot Springs Terraces** - Easy boardwalk loops through white travertine formations
7. **Devils Tower** - View from parking area or easy paved Red Beds Trail
8. **Mormon Row Barns, Grand Teton** - Drive-up photo ops with mountain backdrop
9. **Cloud Gate ("The Bean"), Chicago** - Walk around mirrored sculpture in Millennium Park
10. **Crazy Horse Memorial** - View from visitor center terrace
11. **Wildlife Loop Road, Custer State Park** - 18-mile scenic drive to see bison herds
12. **Hayden Valley, Yellowstone** - Wildlife viewing from pullouts (bison, elk, bears)
13. **Needles Highway, South Dakota** - Scenic drive through granite spires with tunnels
14. **West Thumb Geyser Basin** - Lakeside boardwalk with colorful hot springs
15. **Snake River Overlook, Grand Teton** - Famous Ansel Adams viewpoint, roadside pullout

Bonus Easy Walks (all under 1 km on flat, paved surfaces):

- Door Trail, Badlands (0.75 km boardwalk)
- Fountain Paint Pot, Yellowstone (0.5 km boardwalk loop)
- Upper Geyser Basin, Yellowstone (multiple connected boardwalks, 1-2 km total)
- Chicago Riverwalk (1-2 km, completely flat and scenic)
- Norris Geyser Basin boardwalks (two loops, 0.5-1.5 km each)

Scenic Drives (see attractions from your car):

- Badlands Loop Road - 31 miles (50 km) of otherworldly landscapes
- Wildlife Loop Road, Custer State Park - 18 miles with bison herds
- Needles Highway - granite spires and tunnels framing Mount Rushmore
- Iron Mountain Road - pigtail bridges and tunnel views
- Yellowstone Grand Loop - 142 miles connecting all major sites
- Grand Teton Scenic Drive - mountains reflected in lakes

Alternative Options to Consider

If You Want to Cut 1 Day

- Skip Des Moines stop (Day 12)
- Go directly Chicago from Sioux Falls (longer drive, ~650 km)
- Saves 1 accommodation night (~\$145 CAD)
- Total trip: 14 days instead of 15

If You Want MORE Chicago Time (Add 1 Day)

- Add extra night in Chicago (2 nights total)
- Visit: Art Institute, Field Museum, Shedd Aquarium, Navy Pier, Architecture tour
- Stay through Saturday, depart Sunday
- Cost: +\$200 accommodation, +\$100 meals = +\$300 CAD total

If You Want to Skip Chicago

- Go Cedar Rapids → Kalamazoo direct (Day 13)
- Saves ~\$137 CAD
- Reduces trip by one major city experience
- Shorter driving days on return

If Budget is Tight

- **Skip optional activities** (Wisconsin Dells tour, Chicago observation deck) - saves \$137 CAD
- **Camp 2-3 nights** instead of hotels (Custer, Sioux Falls, Des Moines) - saves \$400-450 CAD
- **Pack more meals** (make sandwiches, skip restaurants for lunch) - saves \$200-300 CAD
- **Drive straight through** some states (skip Mackinaw City, go Windsor to Wisconsin Dells) - saves \$131 CAD
- **Could reduce total to ~\$4,200-4,400 CAD** with above modifications

If You Want More Nature, Less Cities

- Skip Chicago overnight (save \$200)
- Add second night in Jackson, WY
- Extra day for Grand Teton hiking/activities
- Similar total cost, more park time

Pre-Trip Checklist

3 Months Before (By April 7, 2026):

- ☐ Book all 14 hotel accommodations (especially West Yellowstone for July 4th)
- ☐ Compare hotel rates on Booking.com, Hotels.com, Expedia
- ☐ Join hotel loyalty programs for potential discounts (Marriott Bonvoy, Hilton Honors)
- ☐ Purchase America the Beautiful Annual Pass online (optional - can buy at first park)
- ☐ Research and book travel insurance if desired
- ☐ Check passport expiry dates (must be valid through January 2027)
- ☐ Apply for NEXUS cards if interested (faster border crossing)
- ☐ Reserve Chicago observation deck tickets if doing (skip the line)

- ☐ Book any special dining reservations (Chicago deep dish restaurants)

1 Month Before (By May 27, 2026):

- ☐ Confirm all hotel reservations via email/phone
- ☐ Print hotel confirmation numbers
- ☐ Schedule Outlander PHEV service appointment (oil change, tire rotation, multi-point inspection)
- ☐ Check vehicle insurance covers USA travel
- ☐ Verify CAA membership is active and covers USA
- ☐ Download Yellowstone NPS app, GasBuddy, PlugShare, SpotHero
- ☐ Order physical road atlas as backup (Amazon)
- ☐ Start monitoring weather patterns
- ☐ Check for any road closures or construction (WYDOT, SDDOT websites)
- ☐ Review national park alerts (nps.gov/yell)
- ☐ Set up credit card travel notifications (June 27 - July 11, USA)
- ☐ Check current border crossing requirements (ArriveCAN, etc.)

2 Weeks Before (By June 13, 2026):

- ☐ Complete vehicle service/maintenance
- ☐ Test PHEV charging cable at local public charger
- ☐ Purchase any missing camping/outdoor gear
- ☐ Start checking weather forecasts daily
- ☐ Download offline maps for entire route:
 - ☐ Google Maps: Michigan, Wisconsin, South Dakota, Wyoming, Montana, Iowa, Illinois, Indiana
 - ☐ Yellowstone National Park offline map
 - ☐ Grand Teton National Park offline map
- ☐ Purchase road trip snacks (non-perishable)
- ☐ Check for travel advisories or park alerts
- ☐ Renew any prescriptions needed
- ☐ Get haircut if desired (last chance for 2 weeks!)
- ☐ Start breaking in walking shoes if new

1 Week Before (By June 20, 2026):

- ☐ Final hotel confirmation calls (especially West Yellowstone)
- ☐ Print entire itinerary as backup
- ☐ Print hotel addresses and phone numbers
- ☐ Screenshot important confirmations to phone
- ☐ Pack bags (use packing list above)
- ☐ Test all electronics (camera, phone, chargers, power banks)
- ☐ Charge all devices fully
- ☐ Wash car and clean interior
- ☐ Check tire pressure (including spare tire)
- ☐ Verify spare tire, jack, and tools are in vehicle
- ☐ Fill windshield washer fluid
- ☐ Replace wiper blades if needed
- ☐ Organize vehicle documents (registration, insurance, licenses)
- ☐ Prepare "car kit" (first aid, flashlight, emergency supplies)

- ☐ Buy cooler if don't have one
- ☐ Purchase reusable water bottles
- ☐ Stock car snacks (granola bars, nuts, dried fruit)
- ☐ Notify neighbours/family of travel dates
- ☐ Arrange mail/newspaper hold or pickup
- ☐ Set up automatic timers for home lights
- ☐ Clean out fridge of perishables
- ☐ Water house plants or arrange plant care
- ☐ Arrange pet care if applicable

3 Days Before (Wednesday, June 24):

- ☐ Check weather forecast for entire route
- ☐ Adjust packing if weather alerts (extra warm layers, rain gear)
- ☐ Confirm first hotel (Mackinaw City) arrival time
- ☐ Fill prescriptions one last time
- ☐ Withdraw USD cash (\$200-300)
- ☐ Charge all electronics
- ☐ Finalize packing
- ☐ Do laundry
- ☐ Prepare car entertainment (playlists, podcasts, audiobooks)
- ☐ Check vehicle one more time (fluids, lights, battery)
- ☐ Print or save emergency contact list
- ☐ Review wildlife safety rules
- ☐ Check for any last-minute park closures

Day Before Departure (Friday, June 26):

- ☐ **Final vehicle check:**
 - ☐ Full tank of gas
 - ☐ Fully charge PHEV battery
 - ☐ Check all tire pressures (including spare)
 - ☐ Test all lights (headlights, brake lights, turn signals)
 - ☐ Clean windshield inside and out
 - ☐ Test wipers
 - ☐ Verify spare tire and jack are accessible
- ☐ Load luggage into vehicle (pack light - leave room for souvenirs!)
- ☐ Set up phone mounts/chargers in car
- ☐ Pack cooler with drinks and snacks for Day 1
- ☐ Prepare breakfast items for morning (quick departure)
- ☐ Set out clothes for tomorrow
- ☐ Double-check passports are packed
- ☐ Verify wallet has all credit cards and IDs
- ☐ Check hotel confirmation for Mackinaw City one last time
- ☐ Set alarms for 7:00 AM (depart by 9:00 AM)
- ☐ Do final home check:
 - ☐ Lights off
 - ☐ Thermostat adjusted

- ☐ Water main shut off (if concerned)
- ☐ Stove/oven off
- ☐ Windows/doors locked
- ☐ Garage door closed
- ☐ Get good night's sleep! (Big day tomorrow!)

Departure Morning (Saturday, June 27):

- ☐ Eat quick breakfast at home
- ☐ Fill coffee thermoses for road
- ☐ Final bathroom break
- ☐ Quick walk-through of house
- ☐ Set home security if applicable
- ☐ Load any final items
- ☐ Plug in phone navigation
- ☐ Review Day 1 route one more time
- ☐ Take photo of odometer (track mileage for records)
- ☐ **Departure time: 9:00 AM ET** - Let's go!

During Trip - Daily Checklist:

- ☐ Check weather for next day each evening
- ☐ Charge all electronics overnight
- ☐ Charge PHEV at hotel (if available)
- ☐ Review next day's route before bed
- ☐ Keep receipts organized (folder or envelope)
- ☐ Refill water bottles
- ☐ Restock car snacks as needed
- ☐ Take photos/notes for memories
- ☐ Check in with family/friends when signal available
- ☐ Stretch legs every 2 hours of driving
- ☐ Stay hydrated (especially at altitude)

Return Home (Saturday, July 11) - Post-Trip:

- ☐ Unload vehicle
- ☐ Unpack bags
- ☐ Do laundry
- ☐ Download photos from camera
- ☐ Organize receipts for records
- ☐ Calculate actual trip costs vs budget
- ☐ Clean out car (trash, leftover snacks)
- ☐ Check vehicle for any new damage
- ☐ Schedule post-trip vehicle inspection if needed
- ☐ Share photos with family/friends!
- ☐ Write reviews for favorite hotels/restaurants
- ☐ Back up photos to cloud storage
- ☐ Update this itinerary with any tips for future travelers!

Emergency Contacts

- **Roadside Assistance:** Check your auto insurance provider
 - **CAA (Canadian Auto Association):** 1-800-CAA-HELP
 - **US Emergency:** 911
 - **Nearest Hospital:** Google Maps "hospital near me"
-

Summary

This 15-day road trip offers an incredible mix of natural wonders, national parks, and American culture while maintaining moderate costs. The itinerary balances driving days with ample sightseeing time, includes comfortable hotels with charging facilities, and focuses on affordable dining without sacrificing experience.

Key highlights:

- **3 full days in Yellowstone** (including July 4th Independence Day)
- **7 National Parks/Monuments** covered by one America the Beautiful Pass
- **Chicago downtown overnight** with iconic city attractions
- **Minimal hiking** - mostly scenic drives, boardwalks, and viewpoints
- Strategic overnight charging for PHEV at 8 locations
- Comprehensive safety and preparation guides
- Budget at ~**\$5,003 CAD total** (\$2,502 per person)

Trip Statistics:

- Total Distance: 5,700 km
- Days: 15 (14 nights)
- States Visited: 9 (Michigan, Wisconsin, Minnesota, South Dakota, Wyoming, Montana, Iowa, Illinois, Indiana)
- National Parks: Badlands, Wind Cave, Devils Tower, Grand Teton, Yellowstone, Indiana Dunes
- Average Daily Cost: \$334 CAD

Have an amazing trip! Safe travels! 🚗 ✨ 🏞️

Note: All prices are estimates based on 2026 projections. Actual costs may vary. Gas prices fluctuate - budget accordingly. Book accommodations early for July peak season.